Epigraphy, explored the Krishna upstream of Amaravati and came across mounds and standing marble pillars dotted across ‘a wild and desolate spot shut in by a ring of rocky mountains’ and overlooked by ‘a large lozenge-shaped hill of rock about a mile in length with a plateau of sheet rock on top, the edges of which form rugged cliffs all around the summit, converting the latter into a natural fortress, strengthened by brick and stone fortifications now in ruins but showing that at one time the plateau was used as a citadel’. What the scrub in the plains below this citadel concealed were the remains of a city dotted with monastic complexes and small Buddhist *chaitya-griha*s, all in the form of a semi-circular apse at one end and a barrel-vaulted brick roof.[8] This was the once famous Buddhist monastic city of Nagarjunakonda, or ‘the hill of Nagarjuna’, named after one of the great movers and shakers of early Buddhism.

That city is now under water and Nagarjuna’s hilltop monastery is an island. Following the building of the Nagarjuna Sagar dam and reservoir in the 1960s, whatever could be saved in the way of statuary and worked stones from the many Buddhist sites in the valley was taken to pieces and reassembled on the new island above the rising waters. To get there you have to take a boat, and if you are exceptionally lucky, as I was, you might see a pair of amorous leopards frolicking by the water’s edge.

Nagarjunakonda had been named after the Buddhist teacher Nagarjuna, arguably the most important figure in Buddhism after the Buddha himself – although Theravadins, who follow the older and more austere traditions of Buddhism, would disagree. Most of what we know about him comes from Chinese and Tibetan accounts written centuries after his death, much of it fantastical. He is said to have been a Brahmin from Vidarbha, in what is now Maharashtra. As a child he learned all the Vedas by heart, then travelled widely, gaining in knowledge wherever he went. But when